

Sniping SUPERSTARS

The attempts to ostracise a veteran actor bring out the divide in the beleaguered Malayalam film industry even as its two reigning heroes are accused of vendetta

By M.G. Radhakrishnan



MOHANLAL (LEFT)
AND MAMMOOTY

It's a venomous battle that has all of Kerala engrossed as the plot isn't too different from that of a typical Malayalam potboiler. It also has the potential to vertically split, even bleed to death, the local film industry, the fourth largest in the country, but reeling under massive losses. On one side are superstars Mohanlal and Mammootty, both National Award winning actors. Ranged against them is veteran character actor Thilakan, a multiple National Award winner who has played father to both stars in scores of films.

The unseemly war of words has divided the state's cultural world as prominent names from cinema and literature are arraigned in both camps. It has come in the midst of a bitter war between the Association of Malayalam Movie Artistes (AMMA) and Federation of Film Employees of Kerala (FEFKA) on one side and Thilakan on the other. In January, 74-year-old Thilakan accused AMMA and FEFKA of trying to ostracise him from the industry because he acted in a movie whose director heads the rival Malayalam Cine Technicians Association (MACTA). "They want to deny me my livelihood. These associations act like a mafia and they have even threatened to kill me. The artiste in me would commit suicide if they continue this," warned Thilakan.

Though AMMA pleaded innocence of boycotting Thilakan, it suspended him after the actor refused to apologise for calling it a mafia. It has also

THE DIATRIBE COMES AT A TIME WHEN THE MALAYALAM FILM INDUSTRY IS REELING UNDER MOUNTING LOSSES AS 90 PER CENT OF THE FILMS ARE FLOPS.